Medikabiz: AI bill reading

Cost, limits and how to charge shops · prepared 17 October 2026 for Alok ji

Summary

1. Reading one supplier bill with AI costs about **₹1.07** on average (half PDFs, half photos, with GST and card fees). A PDF made by billing software costs about ₹0.32; a photo about ₹1.83.
2. A small shop (~50 bills a month) costs about **₹54** a month; a medium shop (~150 bills) about **₹161**. For 400 shops: about **₹37,510** a month.
3. Money is not the main risk; **Groq's usage limits are**. The free key we use today is enough for only about 15 shops. Upgrade to the Developer plan before launch and check the limits in the table in section 5.
4. The current plans (₹99 a month, ₹999 a year, ₹2,499 lifetime) cannot include unlimited AI reading: a medium shop's AI cost alone is more than the monthly plan. Include a small monthly allowance and sell scan packs (section 7).

1. How Groq charges

Groq charges per **token** (a token is about ¾ of a word; a picture is converted into tokens too). There is no monthly fee and no prepaid balance: usage is billed to a card afterwards. For an Indian billing address the card is charged when usage reaches $1, then $10, then every $100 (about ₹8,800 each time). Below $0.50 nothing is charged.

What is read	Groq model	Per million input tokens	Per million output tokens
PDF with text inside (made by billing software)	openai/gpt-oss-120b	$0.15	$0.60
Photo, or a PDF that is only a scanned photo	qwen/qwen3.8-27b	$0.80	$4.00

Groq's Batch service is 50% cheaper and does not count against the limits, but results can take up to 24 hours (useful for overnight reading).

2. Cost of reading one bill (measured)

Measured on sample bills on 17 Oct 2026. In rupees at ₹88 per dollar, before GST; the last column adds 18% GST and the card's foreign-exchange fee.

Bill	PDF with text	Photo / scan	Photo, with GST + fees
10 lines	$0.0016 = ₹0.14	$0.0070 = ₹0.62	₹0.76
20 lines (typical)	$0.0024 = ₹0.21	$0.0136 = ₹1.20	₹1.46
48 lines (2 pages)	$0.0051 = ₹0.45	$0.0304 = ₹2.68	₹3.27

Average used below: a 20-line bill, half PDFs and half photos, plus 25% for re-reads = **$0.0100 = ₹0.88** before tax, **₹1.07** with GST and fees.

3. Monthly cost per shop

Shop	Bills a month	AI cost a month (with GST + fees)	Cost per bill
Small	50	₹54	₹1.07
Medium	150	₹161	₹1.07
Busy, all photos	200	₹365	₹1.83

4. Monthly cost for all shops

Mix assumed: 5 small shops for every 3 medium ones (an average of 88 bills per shop a month).

Shops	Bills a month	Groq bill (before tax)	Real cost (GST + fees)
20	1,750	$17 = ₹1,536	₹1,876

Shops	Bills a month	Groq bill (before tax)	Real cost (GST + fees)
50	4,375	$44 = ₹3,839	₹4,689
100	8,750	$87 = ₹7,678	₹9,378
200	17,500	$175 = ₹15,357	₹18,755
400	35,000	$349 = ₹30,713	₹37,510

5. Groq limits: will it keep working?

Groq limits how much one account may use **per minute and per day**, for each model separately. When a limit is reached, requests are refused until the minute or day resets. The free key we use now allows about **8,000 tokens a minute and 200,000 a day per model**, which is about 28 bills a day per model, enough for only about 15 shops.

A bill uses about 7,000 tokens including re-reads. 'Busiest minute' assumes a fifth of the day's bills arrive in the busiest hour, and three times that for shops uploading several bills at once.

Shops	Bills a day	Tokens a day	Busiest minute (tokens)	Free key today
20	58	0.4 million	4,083	Not enough
50	146	1.0 million	10,208	Not enough
100	292	2.0 million	20,417	Not enough
200	583	4.1 million	40,833	Not enough
400	1,167	8.2 million	81,667	Not enough

What to do before launch: (1) upgrade the Groq account to the **Developer plan**; (2) open console.groq.com, Settings > Limits and check each model allows at least **60,000 tokens a minute and 10 million tokens a day** (enough for 400 shops with room to spare); (3) if not, ask Groq support for a production limit increase before onboarding many shops. The app will queue bills and wait out short limits by itself, so a busy minute shows 'Trying again...' instead of an error, but a daily limit would make bills wait until the next day.

Important: Groq lists the photo model (qwen3.8-27b) as a **preview** model, 'for evaluation only', which Groq can withdraw at short notice. The PDF model (gpt-oss-120b) is a production model. We should keep a second provider ready for photos (for example Claude or Gemini), and encourage shops to upload PDFs, which are also 5–6 times cheaper and exact.

6. How much to budget on Groq

Groq does not take money in advance, so there is nothing to 'add' up front. Instead, set a **monthly spend limit** (in the Groq console: Settings, Billing, Limits) as a safety cap, with email alerts. When the cap is reached Groq **blocks all reading until the 1st of next month**, so the cap must be well above normal use: we suggest 2.5 times the expected bill.

Stage	Expected Groq bill a month	Spend limit to set	Email alerts at
Pilot (20 shops)	$17 = ₹1,536	$50 = ₹4,400	50%, 75%, 90%
Launch (100 shops)	$87 = ₹7,678	$250 = ₹22,000	50%, 75%, 90%
Growth (200 shops)	$175 = ₹15,357	$450 = ₹39,600	50%, 75%, 90%
Full (400 shops)	$349 = ₹30,713	$900 = ₹79,200	50%, 75%, 90%

Use a card enabled for **international, recurring** payments. Indian cards may refuse automatic foreign charges; Groq's charges of about ₹8,800 each stay under the ₹15,000 limit for automatic recurring debits, but the card must allow e-mandates.

7. How to charge shops

Current plans: Monthly ₹99, Yearly ₹999 (₹83 a month), Lifetime ₹2,499 once. A medium shop's AI reading costs about ₹161 a month, more than the whole monthly plan, and a lifetime plan with unlimited AI would lose money every month, forever.

Proposal	Price	Our AI cost (worst case: all photos)	Why
Included in Monthly / Yearly	20 bills a month	₹37	Every shop tries it and sees the value; costs at most a third of ₹99
Lifetime plan	20 bills a month for the first year, then packs	-	A one-time price cannot pay for AI every month
Scan pack: 100 bills	₹199	₹183	Covers even all-photo shops; good margin on PDFs
Scan pack: 300 bills	₹499	₹548	For busy shops; works out to ₹1.66 a bill
Or: AI plan add-on	₹199 a month, up to 150 bills	₹274	Simple for medium shops; fair-use limit protects us

In the app: show **'Bills left this month'** on the scan screen, warn at 80%, and when the allowance is used up, offer a pack or typing the bill by hand, never a sudden error at the counter. Count every bill as one, whether PDF or photo, to keep it simple; PDFs are the cheap case and give the margin.

8. Assumptions

Prices from Groq's model page on 17 Oct 2026; token counts measured on sample bills the same day. ₹88 per dollar. 18% GST on imported services under reverse charge (ask the CA) and about 3.5% card foreign-exchange fee. 50 bills a month for a small shop and 150 for a medium one, 20 lines each, half PDFs and half photos, 25% extra for re-reads. Real shops will differ: the Groq console shows actual usage, and we should check these numbers after the first month of the pilot.